

Structural Analysis of Rzewski's Variations on People United

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Last Edited May 7, 2026

Thesis Statement

The use of “non-tonality” - that is, an extremely intentional blend of tonal and atonal techniques and structures - and popular idioms - including Jazz, Blues, and various American Folk Musics - in Frederic Rzewski's *The People United Will Never Be Defeated* establishes a dual* discourse of representations of class and race in the standard “Classical” piano repertoire that urges the pianist to dismantle imagined genre/stylistic barriers - “conventions” - and pursue a more holistic approach to both the piano instrument and a broader engagement with music as a whole.

Annotated Bibliography

Wason, R. W. (1988). Tonality and atonality in frederic rzewski's variations on "the people united will never be defeated!" *Perspectives of New Music*, 26(1), 108–143. Retrieved April 13, 2026, from <http://www.jstor.org/stable/833319>

This source is a perfect entry-point into the extremely deliberate construction of each Variation. Though I intend to survey each "movement" and primarily focus on the last "movement", this in-depth analysis of the first "movement" is a great introduction to some of the requisite language and analytical techniques for a proper exploration of the Variations. I'm also planning on using the chart of key relationships and styles - the "Sketch of the Overall Form" - depicted in Example 19.

Rzewski, F. (2007). *Nonsequiturs: Writings and lectures on improvisation, composition, and interpretation*. MusicTekte

In *Nonsequiturs*, Rzewski details his own thoughts on composition and interpretation of his music, with explicit reference to the Variations. This is the perfect primary source - from the composer himself! - to start exploration of class/race struggles as depicted in the Variations. I'm most excited to relate political discourses from his essays "We are the pupils of the working class" and "The Composer and the Tradition of Art Music".

Spener, D. (2016). A song, socialism, and the 1973 military coup in chile. In *We shall not be moved/no nos moverán: Biography of a song of struggle* (pp. 17–26). Temple University Press. Retrieved April 13, 2026, from <http://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt1kft8ff.5>

Though not explicitly about the song *The People United Will Never Be Defeated*, this source will be used to relate Chilean protest music to the 1973 military coup and the contemporaneous political sphere. This analysis will prove useful to understanding current discourses with political musics and the effect of 2020s performance of *The People United*.

Asplund, C. (1995). Frederic rzewski and spontaneous political music. *Perspectives of New Music*, 33(1/2), 418–441. Retrieved April 14, 2025, from <http://www.jstor.org/stable/833713>

Asplund dives deep into the emotional responses of particular technical constructions in some of Rzewski's other musics. I'm quite interested in his analyses of *Coming Together + Attica* and *Les Moutons de Panurge* because of their reliance on heavy audience engagement and interaction. Additionally, there is some very informative writing on the didactic, revolutionary, and class-conscious and collective nature of Rzewski's writing which I plan to expand upon.

Metzer, D. (2021). Prisoners' voices: Frederic Rzewski's coming together and attica. *The Journal of Musicology*, 38(1), pp. 109–139. Retrieved April 10, 2025, from <https://www.jstor.org/stable/48771517>

Here, Metzer argues that the construction of Rzewski's music is itself discourse on prison architecture, image, and abolition. Though Metzer indicates that much of Rzewski's music is relevant to this conversation, he focuses primarily on the works "Coming Together" and "Attica", which are uniquely related in that they are both written about and in the aftermath of the Attica State Prison Riots. He argues that the minimalist, repeating musical structure of the pieces is representative of the mental landscape of one in isolation, leading to a restless *moto perpetuo* in "Coming Together" and a still reflection in "Attica". Metzer's work is foundational in contextualising music as informationally dense and a strong carrier of political messaging.

Rzewski, F. (1995). Inner voices. *Perspectives of New Music*, 33(1/2), 404–417.

Retrieved April 14, 2025, from <http://www.jstor.org/stable/833712>

I am lucky to have found so much writing by Rzewski about the construction of his own mmusic. This essay explores ideas of musical improvisation and composition as structured improvisation. Additionally, Rzewski elaborates much on his own compositional/improvisational frameworks and how he applies them. Though there's no explicit mention of any of his music - it's all writing about his own ideologies - it provides some groundwork for a robust and personal analysis of his musics.

References

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